

The Syrian refugee crisis, as a result of the continuing civil war that began in 2011, has displaced over 13 million people so far. Millions of which have sought refuge in neighboring countries such as Lebanon and Turkey, as well as further away in Europe. However, the global response has been marked particularly by a distinct lack of equality and as well as shared responsibility (UNHCR, 2023). Critical theory provides us with a suitable framework for examining and analyzing the systemic structures that are driving the crisis, as well as exploring possible situations, and finally reimagining justice in the context of this crisis.

This refugee crisis has been exacerbated by the unequal distribution of responsibility between richer and poorer nations. Wealthier countries, for example in the global north reinforce severely restrictive immigration policies and often outsource responsibility and/or management of refugees to bordering (often less affluent) nations such as Turkey or Jordan. These countries have hosted, and still do, the majority of Syrian refugees despite having less resources to do so, as well as being overburdened with their arrival (UNHCR, 2023). This highly unequal dynamic reflects a global hierarchy that prioritizes national interests in the global north while overburdening global south countries with hosting refugees.

Another issue is the commodification of refugees within the global order. For example, the European Union's agreement with Turkey in 2016, outsourced the responsibility of hosting refugees, as well as treating them as political pawns in exchange for financial and diplomatic leverage (Demirbaş & Miliou, 2023). Additionally, mainstream media, particularly in the global north (but not limited to) amplify the narrative, among many others, that refugees are an economic burden or security threat, which increases hostility, prejudice, and discrimination, and leads to exclusionary policies.

In host countries, like Lebanon, refugees face systemic oppression through limited access to basic institutions or rights such as healthcare, education and employment. Additionally, many are forced into exploitative jobs (usually labor work) and are reliant on aid – while international aid regimes are already underfunded (Betts & Collier, 2018).

Critical theory emphasizes the need to dismantle systemic inequalities and to foster collective responsibility. Habermas's (1984) concept of communicative action highlights the importance of important and honest dialogue between nations to challenge the paradigm of individualism and to promote a shared responsibility towards refugees. Fairer policies could include, for example, increasing refugee quotas in global north countries and providing financial resources, as well as technical support, for host countries in the global south.

However, addressing the root causes of displacement is also of crucial importance. Support for peacebuilding, reconstruction, and political stability in Syria can massively reduce the need for people to flee in fear of their lives. In global north countries, on a societal level, education is also a vital step towards combatting xenophobia and the

problematization of refugees. Teaching people about the root causes of the refugee crisis and emphasizing a collective sense of shared identity can also reduce prejudice and discrimination.

Justice for refugees necessitates respecting their human dignity and rights, as well as moving beyond the idea of charity and towards a rights-based approach. Honneth's (1995) theory of recognition argues that justice involves acknowledging and affirming the inherent humanity and dignity of marginalized groups. This specific principle could be crucial in reshaping policies on refugees within our global order.

Critical theory also specifically challenges the nation-state system, which prioritizes the domestic citizen's rights over the needs of refugees ("us vs them"). A perhaps more inclusive idea of citizenship, one which could be rooted in global cooperation and solidarity with one another, could greatly assist us in achieving justice for refugees. Finally, addressing the refugee crisis could also lead us to broader systemic change, such as reducing global power dynamics and inequality, but also even rethinking how power is distributed within our global order.

In conclusion, the Syrian refugee crisis provides a perfect case study in illustrating how global systems of power and inequality help to perpetuate suffering and hinder solutions. By using critical theory, we can uncover the root cause of said challenges and propose a fair and more humanistic approach to refugees. Refugees deserve dignity, safety, and equality, and in addressing their needs we not only fulfill our moral obligations, but we also get the opportunity to create a more just and humane global order.

References:

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